

Let's turn now to a second, shorter argument in favor of immaterial
souls.

Consider my body. It has many parts: my arms, my legs, etc. But it also has parts we don't have ready names for. For example, there is all of my body besides my right arm. And all of me besides my left big toe. And ...

This shows that there are in fact many overlapping physical things in your seat right now. By itself, that is arguably not especially puzzling.

There is at least one thing (hopefully) thinking in your seat right now.

If there are no immaterial souls, then that thing is a material thing.

What would it take for a material thing to think? Presumably, if material things can think, thinking is just a matter of that material thing having a certain kind of complex physical organization. Maybe it would have to have some kind of complex information-processing features analogous to our brain. Let's call these the **thinking-relevant physical properties**,

But note that many of the distinct physical things sitting in your seat right now have the thinking-relevant properties. For example, the object which is all of you other than your left thumb's fingernail would seem to.

So, if material things can think, there are a huge number of distinct
thinking things in your seat right now.

1. If physical things can think, then any physical thing with the thinking-relevant properties can think.
2. There are many distinct things with the thinking-relevant properties in your seat right now.
3. If physical things can think, there are many distinct thinkers in your seat right now. (1,2)
4. There are not many distinct thinkers in your seat right now.
5. Physical things cannot think. (3,4)
6. You can think.
7. You are not a wholly physical thing. (5,6)
8. If we are not wholly physical things then immaterial souls exist.

C. Immaterial souls exist. (7,8)

THE MANY THINKERS ARGUMENT

Could you deny premise (4), and accept many thinkers?

Maybe. But what goes for thinking plausibly goes for sensations like pain as well.

Do we have a moral obligation to avoid causing pain to larger people, on the ground that they contain more parts with the pain-relevant properties, so that harming them causes more individuals to feel pain?

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